

The Language of Maths

Your child may know the maths. The question is whether they know what the question is asking.

In the 11+, a great many marks are lost not because a child cannot do the maths, but because they did not recognise what was being asked of them.

A question rarely says "multiply these numbers". It says *find the product*. It does not say "subtract". It says *how much more*. Same maths. Different clothing.

This is the decoder. Work through it together, a few lines at a time, until the words stop being a barrier.

Start here: the inverse

Every operation has an opposite, and this is how your child checks their own work.

The inverse of addition is subtraction. The inverse of subtraction is addition.

The inverse of multiplication is division. The inverse of division is multiplication.

If they worked out $47 + 28 = 75$, they can check it with $75 - 28$. If the answer is 47, they were right. This one habit catches more careless errors than any amount of extra practice.

Words that mean add +

All of these are asking for the same thing.

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	FOR EXAMPLE
Sum of	Add	The sum of 14 and 9
Total	Add	The total cost of both items
Altogether / in all	Add	How many does she have altogether?
Increased by	Add	The price increased by £3
More than	Add	Tom has 5 more than Ann
Between them	Add	How many do they have between them?

Words that mean subtract –

This group causes the most trouble, because several sound like addition.

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	FOR EXAMPLE
Difference between	Subtract	The difference between 40 and 25
How many more	Subtract	How many more does Ann need?
How much is left	Subtract	How much change is left?
Reduced by / less than	Subtract	Reduced by a quarter
Fewer	Subtract	She has 6 fewer marbles
Find the change	Subtract	How much change from £5?
Deduct / decrease	Subtract	Deduct 15 from the total

The classic trap. "More than" can mean add or subtract, depending on where it sits. "Tom has 5 more than Ann" means add 5 to Ann's. But "how many more does Tom have?" means subtract. Teach your child to ask: am I being told a fact, or asked a question?

Words that mean multiply ×

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	FOR EXAMPLE
Product of	Multiply	The product of 7 and 8
Times / lots of	Multiply	Three lots of 12
Double / triple	Multiply	Double the number
Of (with fractions)	Multiply	Two thirds of 60
Per / each	Multiply	£4 each for 6 tickets
Groups of / lots of	Multiply	4 groups of 7

Words that mean divide ÷

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	FOR EXAMPLE
Quotient	Divide	The quotient of 36 and 4
Shared equally	Divide	Shared equally between 5
Split / grouped into	Divide	Split into groups of 6
Half / a third of	Divide	A third of the class
Per (unit rate)	Divide	Cost per kilogram
Partition	Divide	Partition into equal parts
How many in	Divide	How many 5s in 40?

Words that trip children up

These are not operations. They are instructions about the answer.

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	WATCH OUT FOR
Remainder	What's left over	Not the answer itself
Estimate	Round first, then work	An exact answer loses the mark
Consecutive	One after another	7, 8, 9
At least	That number or more	Includes the number itself
Express in terms of	Give the answer using that unit	Check minutes vs hours
Simplify	Reduce to lowest form	Fractions and ratios
Inclusive	Count both ends	1 to 8 March inclusive is 8 days
Divisible by	Divides exactly, no remainder	36 is divisible by 9
Approximate	Round off, close to	Approximately 200
Decimal fraction	A fraction written as a decimal	One and a half is 1.5

The inclusive trap. "How many days from 1 March to 8 March inclusive?" The answer is 8, not 7, because inclusive means you count both ends. Children who subtract $8 - 1$ lose the mark. The opposite word is exclusive, where you do not count the ends.

Comparing and ordering

These decide the shape of the answer, not the calculation.

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	FOR EXAMPLE
Ascending	Smallest first	Write in ascending order
Descending	Largest first	Order them descending
Greatest / least	Largest / smallest	Which is the least?
Greater than / less than	A comparison, not a sum	Which is greater, $\frac{3}{4}$ or 0.8?
Between	Not including the ends	A number between 10 and 20
Round to	Nearest given value	Round to the nearest 10

Number words worth knowing

Children often meet these for the first time in the exam itself.

WHEN YOU SEE	IT MEANS	FOR EXAMPLE
Factor	Divides into it exactly	Factors of 12: 1,2,3,4,6,12
Multiple	In its times table	Multiples of 5: 5,10,15
Prime	Only 1 and itself	2, 3, 5, 7, 11
Square number	A number times itself	16 is 4×4
Digit	A single figure	47 has two digits

The quick card

Print this bit and put it where your child works. Four words to scan for.

ADD +

sum, total, altogether,
increased by

SUBTRACT -

difference, how many more,
left, fewer

MULTIPLY ×

product, lots of, double, of,
each

DIVIDE ÷

quotient, shared, split, per, a
third of

Try it together

Do not solve these. Just underline the word that tells you what to do, and say which operation it is.

1. Find the difference between 84 and 37.

Which word gave it away?

2. A box holds 6 pencils. How many pencils are in 9 boxes?

There is no obvious word here. What tells you?

3. Sam has 24 stickers and gives a third of them away. How many does he give away?

Two clues in this one.

4. Ella has 15 sweets. Ben has 4 more than Ella. How many does Ben have?

Careful. This is the trap.

5. 48 chairs are shared equally between 8 rows. How many per row?

Which word decides it?

6. How many days are there from 1 March to 8 March inclusive?

One word changes the answer completely.

Answers: 1 difference, subtract. 2 the repeated groups, multiply. 3 "a third of", divide. 4 "more than" stating a fact, so add. 5 "shared equally", divide. 6 "inclusive", count both ends, so 8 days not 7.

How to use this at home

Do not hand it over and hope. Take one table a week. When your child works through a practice paper, ask them to *underline the word that tells them what to do* before they calculate anything. Within a few weeks they will do it without being asked, and that habit is worth more than any single table on this page.



From a parent to parents ♥

Jedon 11+ · Navigating together